

Project 12

Course Code and Name: MSJ 3243 Speech Writing and Public Speaking

Project Name: Network Propaganda

Project Type: Persuasive Speech

Semester of Submission: Spring 2025

Project Description:

This project involved writing and delivering a persuasive speech on “Network Propaganda” and the spread of misinformation through social media. It explored echo chambers, emotional manipulation, AI-generated content, declining trust, social division, and manipulated elections. The project included audience demographic, cognitive, affective, behavioral, and SWOT analyses to understand the target audience. The speech concluded with a call to action encouraging audiences to think critically and verify the information they consume.

Project Justification:

I chose this topic because of my growing concern, as a media studies and journalism student, about how algorithms, emotional framing, and audience segmentation are used to spread false information and manipulate public opinion. The project let me apply speechwriting techniques, audience analysis frameworks, and persuasive delivery methods to a topic directly relevant to media literacy.



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Final Project

MSJ 3243: Speech Writing and Public Speaking

(Sec 1 :)

Submitted to

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Summary and background of Network Propaganda

In the post truth era, mis/disinformation is spread through hyped social media platforms. Before technology, propaganda was only controlled state wise. Also, known as Echo Chamber - algorithms show what people engage in more, this leads to selective exposure of information. Strong emotions (fear, anger, hope) have the upper hand than factual accuracy. Recently, AI is amplifying messages, and creating content, which adds massively to the trend. These lead to disturbing outcomes like, break in trust, societal divination and controlled election and law making.

Furthermore, people usually consume facts, and based on those facts misinformation is spread, and based on those misinformation, the mass audience takes action for a cause or belief, which has a hidden agenda (blurred from public). These actions are triggered by disinformation campaigns; by editing people's reality with emotions, mis/disinformation, social media networks, target audience segmentation, strategic timing and political influence. These factors lead to mass harm like, political instability, public health risks and economic manipulation.

To counter these we need digital and media literacy, fact checking efficiency, and transparency in algorithms.

Motivation to Work on this Project

I developed the interest to work on this project because I grew concerned about how false information propagates among the public using digital networks together with propaganda techniques. The interaction between social media algorithms, emotional tactics and user segmentations creates false information which increases social divisions between people according to my observations as a media studies and journalism student. Through my experience I was driven to teach about "network propaganda" that shows how purposefully built misinformation moves from point to point across digital networks. The aim of my project focused on showing my audience how users under 35 years old and those significantly active on social media become unknowingly manipulated to help them develop media literacy as well.

Demographic analysis of my audience

Category	Description
Age Group	a) 17-35 years old will be the primary audience (university students, young entrepreneurs, etc.) b) 35-50 years old will be a secondary audience (working class, tutors, etc.)
Education Level	a) University students who are studying sociology, technology and media. b) Curious students c) People who research digital ethics and media literacy.
Occupation and Interests	a) Teachers and students b) Media professionals c) Activists d) People with knowledge of algorithm biases e) Social media users
Geographical Location	a) Urban - based region, with high social media usage.
Attitudes and Beliefs	a) People who question mainstream narratives b) Public who are concerned about digital influence c) Emotionally driven
Media Consumption Habits	a) User heavily engaged in social media platforms b) People with blend of traditional news source and online news source

Challenges they Face	a) Struggles to differentiate propaganda from fact b) Selective exposure to contents c) Lack of digital literacy
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Audience Analysis

Aspects	Objectives
Cognitive (what they should know)	a) Understanding how mis/disinformation spreads through social media b) Understanding how facts are belittled by emotions c) Understanding and be aware of propaganda techniques d) Understanding how media influences politics, economy and public point of view
Affective (what they should feel)	a) Sense of betrayal when they understand, what they were a part of b) Eager to know truth, and about hidden agendas c) Motivated and empowered to get rid of media manipulation d) Sense of irritation towards partial media, and political and corporate control over information
Behavioral (what they should do)	a) Think in details and with reason b) Seek to know different perspectives c) Fact checking before having an opinion d) Question authorities for the details , they have the right to know

Situational Analysis (SWOT)

Strengths

1. This group maintains digital involvement with social communities.
2. These individuals portray their emotions tightly into their social and political interests.
3. Their interest in critical thinking allows them to question widely accepted mainstream stories.

Weaknesses

1. Low media literacy.
2. The user experiences difficulty in detecting propaganda sources alongside false information spread online.

Opportunities

1. The establishment of media literacy campaigns serves universities as an approach to promote this essential skill set.
2. The organization teaches youth empowerment by conducting workshops which address fact-checking and critical thinking.
3. Teachers and media professionals should work together with the project to promote awareness campaigns.
4. Teaching audience members about algorithm transparency and ethical discussions about technology represents a fourth opportunity.

Threats

1. Increasing AI-driven disinformation and emotional manipulation.
2. Social and political divisions reach deeper intensity through the function of echo chambers.
3. Declining trust in authentic news and democratic institutions.

Transitions between Mid-term and Final Project

The project overall has three changes like addition of situational analysis, the changes in my project and the way the speech is to be delivered. The speech took a few turns, like shortening the introduction, which is more precise now. Deducting one of the actual events, so that I could

concentrate on a certain event and make it clearer. Also, some of the vague information was chopped off.

I am interested in using the extemporaneous way of delivering the speech, using it fits well with a class presentation, where i can use short notes to deliver my speech.

Speech Opening

When will you realize you are being used? Do you not get disheartened when you realize you were blind? But, most importantly don't you think you as an individual have a responsibility to get out of this trap?

You should know, narratives are framed by highlighting the information we are supposed to intake, while the vital ones are overshadowed. People need to know how lies are blended with the truth, and how we are being directly and indirectly used for someone else's benefit. The control of our thought, emotions and action, based on misleading information is what we call propaganda. These are mostly hidden in politics, advertisements and religion.

Body

Slogans and catchphrases in news are injected within us frequently, this repetition allows us to believe what we hear more often. Also, propaganda triggers emotional aspects to make us bypass our rational thinking. More importantly, selective figures are used to motivate us to believe in something which is not completely true, this also includes entertainment and pop culture influences. The idea of Black and White thinking makes a barrier for us to think about the complex sides of a certain topic, thus limiting our critical thinking. Truly, I trust we are not this blind. We should consider who is actually profiting from this propaganda, why we judge and select sides by knowing one side of the story, and what is blurring our vision.

Moreover, misleading information forces us to take false actions. How? We buy products, where we believe it has supporting causes. A recent survey concluded by a non-profit organization stated that products can get banned by the government, due to incorrect data. Biased media and politicians favor one side, maybe because their main goal is profit, not authentic public knowledge.

Actual stories include surprisingly bizarre tactics which are still in argument. One theory suggests, Titanic didn't sink back in 1912, but its sister ship Olympic, switched for insurance

claims, where approximately 1500 people sank and died. Was their death worth the amount of the insurance claim?

Conclusion

Call to action

People, it's high time we start thinking critically, find truth rather than choosing it, and don't let others decide what you should think. You know the media part best, I'm sure! Finally, now it is for you to decide whether whatever I said was a part of a propaganda or not! Thank you for listening.

References:-

1. <https://apnews.com/>
2. <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2021/10/18/bangladesh-hindus-men-killed-temples-vandalised-religious-violence>
3. <http://www.saylor.org/books>

Learnings and Outcomes (Self-reflection):

- I learned how misinformation spreads through digital networks.
- I learned that emotions can influence people more strongly than facts.
- I learned the importance of media and digital literacy.
- I learned how to analyze and understand my target audience.
- I developed my communication and presentation skills.